Barbie in Therapy

By Denise Duhamel

INTRODUCTION

Long before Greta Gerwig ever handed Barbie an existential crisis on the big screen – "Barbie in the real world? That's impossible." -- poet Denise Duhamel imagined Barbie as a perpetually smiling heroine who could barely name a feeling and who worried more about her therapy outfit than her trauma.

But after intense introspection led by therapist Dr. Midge, that once anxious doll becomes a raging, hilarious revolutionary, smashing her tiny appliances and shedding every fake accessory.

Duhamel's Barbie poems deliver a sharp, witty prequel to the Barbie Movie's awakening only messier, louder, and with far fewer musical numbers.

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BARBIE IN THERAPY

(Pg 68-69) During the first visit, Dr. Midge asks Barbie to
relax
and talk a little bit about her past.
But Barbie, the quintessential people-pleaser, doesn't know
how

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to do anything but smile. She's afraid
to tell Dr. Midge about the violence
of where she's come from: so many rolling heads
just like her own tumbling down a factory conveyor belt.
Her first pain was her hair being sewn
with a needle onto her bald scalp.
She never had time for any kind of childhood.
Not quite an orphan, yet not quite part of a family,
Barbie finds she's been given so little vocabulary
to talk about her feelings. *Try,* coaxes Dr. Midge,
tapping her pen on her pad. *I feel . . . frustrated,*
Barbie finally says, bursting into what would be sobs
If she possessed tear glands. *What do I wear*
to therapy? Barbie wants to know. Dr. Midge
recognizes her client's question as avoidance,
but answers anyway believing in not pushing too fast.
Sweatpants are good, Dr. Midge says, *or anything loose*
so you can feel comfortable lying on the couch.
Dr. Midge asks Barbie to draw a picture of herself
to use as a springboard, something for them to talk about.
Barbie renders herself perfectly, just as she appears
on the packaging she comes in. Dr. Midge is thrown –

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She's used to having anorectics draw themselves as blobs,
or the heavier women scratching out little stick figures.
You are quite an artist, Dr. Midge praises, double-checking
to see if Barbie has included all her limbs.
I have a little pallet at home, Barbie says.
It came with an easel, smock, and beret.
Really? Asks Dr. Midge, interested. Barbie answers,
dejected,
Yes, but there's no real paint, so what's the point?
That must make you angry, coaxes Dr. Midge.
No real food in your fridge. No real hay
For your palomino's western stable.
Barbie asks her shrink to explain what anger is,
and Dr. Midge suggests several good books.
She gives Barbie therapy-homework, asking her to punch
her pillows every night before she goes to bed.
Barbie writes out her first check, hoping
that just around the corner, she'll get to the real issues
which are full and fleshy, and anything but plastic.

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BARBIE IN THREAPY, PART II

(Pg 80 Excerpt) Barbie is starting to become dependent
on Dr. Midge's every word. The patient asks her doctor:
What should I do about exercise? Run in place each
morning
or jump on my personal trampoline? In conversation
with other Barbies, she often starts sentences
with *My therapist says . . .* The other dolls notice
she has a certain glow that she hadn't had before,
but Barbie's sisters aren't crazy
about all her changes. She's begun, every once in a while,
to say no, not wanting to share her fantasy clothes
because of something called boundaries. Barbies past
comes back
to her in flashes, like mini-deaths:
little boys poking their sticky fingers;
Pet dogs gnawing on her hands.
And just how is she supposed to feel about Ken?
Sometimes he's a soda jerk, a book worm, a mere bowling
partner.
Then other times she's thrust next to him – he in a tux,
she in a wedding dress . . .

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BARBIE'S FINAL TRIP TO THERAPY

(Pg 86-88) *There's nothing wrong with me!*

There's something wrong with society!

Barbie screams, gutturally, the way human babies do
when they're hungry. Over the months, her voice
has grown from tinny to raspy,
tentative to commanding, deepening every time Dr. Midge
comments
about Barbie's newest breakthrough.
Barbie has learned that depression is nothing
but anger turned inward, so now, as she lashes
out towards the world, she giggles, too,
because the expulsion of energy feels so good.
If she were a lazier doll, Barbie would wait
for the world to change. Because
she is so well-preserved, she'd still look the same
one hundred, even two hundred years from now –
if that's how long it takes to get the E.R.A. passed,
if that's how long it takes for women to be safe on the
streets.
But afraid those days for her kind will never come
when the results of her activism seem slow or null,
Barbie wishes she could immediately skip over to the
afterlife –
hoping Mattel's manufactured her a toy-soul that isn't sold
separately. Never really having felt full-fledged suicidal,
Barbie talks about this longing with her therapist
on her last visit. Dr. Midge is reassuring –
all great thinkers ponder what will happen after death.
Dr. Midge is confident Barbie is ready to strike
out on her own and recaps her patient's psychological
accomplishments
and growth, the doctor saying she's learned quite a lot
about herself as well. With a firm handshake, the two dolls
try
to say goodbye at the end of the hour, then fall
into each other's less professional hugs.
Barbie will miss her shrink, but Dr. Midge, preparing
her client for separation, has taught her
to also include other women in her life.
Barbie's begun hanging out with Lisa Sliwa,
The national director of the Guardian Angels.
The two will be interviewed for magazines, proposing all
men

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who rape should be castrated. Barbie is sick
of taking cabs at night, of double-locking the back door
to her Furnished Glamour Home before she ascends the
spiral
staircase to her bedroom. She knows more women
go to see therapists than men, that more women
have been locked up in looney bins,
so a combination of history and current events
prompts her to smash her three thimble-size saucepans.
After her final therapy session, she crushes
her tea kettle that never learned how to whistle
with the pointed heel of her pump. She tosses
the toaster out of the picture window
of her Sweet Roses Living Room. Then, out
with the tasteless make-believe toast. Her poodle
and daisy apron, her MBA briefcase,
her Oscar De La Renta dresses. Sick of posing
as anything but herself, she's even tired
of the oversized shirts she's borrowed from Kin.
That same night, she takes a midnight jog, past her lawn
which looks as though it's been set up
as a garage sale of fashion accessories. She's naked

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as the first day she was made in the factory,
as naked as Eve, as Lady Godiva, as naked as Jane
when she took off her animal skins
to escape the jungle and her bad marriage with Tarzan.
Barbie is as vulnerable as Cinderella
in that split second between her dissolving rags
and the instant gown her Fairy God Mother bestowed her.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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